



CLAUDE IN SCHOOLS

The Educator's Guide to Claude

A practical handbook for teachers and school leaders

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Colophon

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A note on how this guide was made

This guide was written with the assistance of Claude itself. The structure, positions, arguments, and editorial judgment are the author's. AI helped with drafting, formatting, and building the document. Every page has been reviewed and edited by a human before publication — the same standard the guide recommends for any classroom use of AI.

Pricing & feature notes

Pricing and features are accurate as of October 2026. Anthropic updates plans, pricing, and features regularly. For current information, visit *claude.ai*.

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Three principles that shape this guide

Before the how, a word on the why. Anyone can list Claude's features. Few guides take a position on what the tool is actually for — and what it is not for. This one does. Three principles sit behind every recommendation in the pages that follow.

The teacher is the expert

Claude is a tool. You are the teacher. The tool does not set the learning goals. It does not know your students. It does not understand the pedagogical choices you have made and why. You do. Every output Claude produces passes through your professional judgment before it reaches a classroom. This is not a nice idea — it is the working rule.

Your knowledge, your experience, your discernment: these are what make any AI output actually useful. If you understand differentiation deeply, Claude becomes a force multiplier. If you don't, no AI will fill the gap. The tool amplifies what you already bring; it does not replace it.

Do the fundamentals better

The temptation with new technology is always to do new things — escape rooms, virtual reality excursions, gamified everything. Most of it is noise. The real opportunity is quieter. It is to do the evidence-based fundamentals more often and more consistently than you currently can.

Retrieval practice. Vocabulary work. Text differentiation. Sentence stems. Worked examples. Formative feedback. These are the practices the research keeps pointing to, and the practices teachers have always said they would use more often — if they had the time. Claude gives you the time. What used to take ninety minutes of preparation now takes five. That is not flashy. It is transformative in the only sense that matters: students learn more.

JOHAN'S NOTE

After nearly three decades in classrooms and leadership roles, I have watched a lot of tools arrive with the promise of changing education. The ones that stayed were the ones that let teachers do more of what they already knew worked. The ones that vanished were the ones that asked teachers to become something else. Claude is one of the best AI tools I have seen that clearly belongs in the first group — if you use it well.

—JL

Include every student

Every classroom has students on the margins. The EAL student who needs key vocabulary pre-taught to access the text everyone else is reading. The student with a learning difficulty who needs the same content at a simplified reading age. The advanced student who is coasting because the work is not stretching them. Meeting all of these students, every lesson, has always been the right thing to do — and has always been too time-consuming to do consistently.

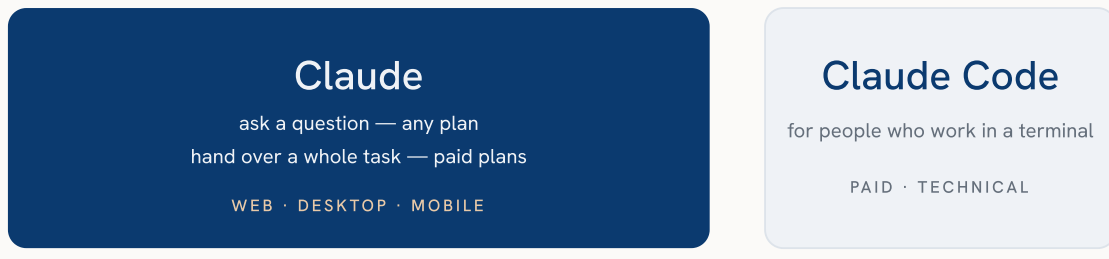
Claude lowers that time cost to the point where it becomes realistic. Differentiated texts in five minutes. Translated key terms. Scaffolded instructions. Audio versions of written tasks. This is not about doing more. It is about doing what matters, for the students who need it most, at a cadence the research has recommended for decades.

WATCH OUT

Claude can help you create resources faster. It cannot replace the relational work of teaching. Do not let the efficiency of AI trick you into spending less time with students. The time AI saves is for them — not for more admin.

Understanding the Claude ecosystem

Claude is one product, and the question is never which one to open. It is how much you are asking for. A question gets an answer. A whole job gets taken on and carried out. The only real fork is Claude Code, a separate tool for people who work in a terminal, and most teachers will never need it. Five minutes spent on this page saves a lot of confusion later.



One Claude, reached from a browser, a desktop app or a phone. The choice that matters is not where you go — it is how much you hand over.

One Claude, two kinds of request

The first kind is the conversation everybody pictures: you type a prompt, read the response, decide the next step, and type again. You are steering, one move at a time. The second kind is a job description rather than a question — several steps, several outputs, one finished result — and here Claude plans the work, carries it out, and uses tools along the way until it is finished. Same account, same box you type into. You are not selecting a product. You are deciding how much of the work to hand over, and Part 3 is where the second kind is taught properly.

Anthropic used to keep the two apart, as chat and as a separate mode called Cowork, and is now merging them into a single Claude — the Pro and Max plans first, with Team and Free to follow. Two colleagues may therefore see slightly different screens for a while. The screen you happen to have changes nothing about how the work itself is done: if your Claude still offers Cowork as a separate choice, handing a job over costs you one extra click and nothing more, and every page that follows applies unchanged. A separate question, and not a question of timing, is whether handing over is available to you in the first place. That one turns on your plan, and the table further down this page sets it out.

Where you reach Claude

At claude.ai in a browser, in the Claude Desktop app on macOS and Windows, and in the iOS and Android apps — one account across all three. There is also a Claude side panel for Chrome. It is available on the Max and Team plans, is rolling out to Pro, and on Enterprise plans appears wherever an administrator has switched it on.

Do not underrate the phone. Voice input is the hidden productivity feature: a teacher I work with drafts her weekly parent communications during her commute by dictating, then edits on the laptop at home. The phone is not where you build; it is where you capture and review.

None of this requires a paid plan to try. The free tier gives you access to Claude Sonnet 5.5, file uploads, web search, memory across conversations, and the ability to produce downloadable documents. Ninety per cent of teachers will do ninety per cent of their work with no more than that.

Claude Code — the developer tool (paid, technical)

This is the one place where you really do choose between two things: opening Claude, or opening Claude Code. Claude Code is a command-line tool for developers and IT-curious staff. It lets Claude read and write files on your computer and run programs. For most teachers this is not a daily tool, but it is where Claude becomes most powerful — and where your school's tech staff or curriculum lead may want to spend time. Part 3 includes a short glimpse so you know what it is.

What you get on each plan

Plan	Price	Best for	Includes
Free	\$0	Trying it; light personal use	Claude Sonnet 5.5, web search, memory, file uploads, file creation, mobile apps
Pro	~\$20 / month	A teacher's daily workhorse	Everything in Free, plus access to Opus 5.5, <i>handing over whole tasks</i> , larger usage limits, unlimited Projects
Max	\$100+ / month	Power users, departments	Everything in Pro, plus 5-20× usage, higher output limits, early access to new features

Pricing accurate as of October 2026. Check claude.ai for current pricing. These are Anthropic's individual plans; team and enterprise plans differ in pricing and features.

WATCH OUT · PRIVACY

Whether your conversations are used to train Anthropic's models is a per-account setting, so read it rather than assume it. It sits one level deeper than most people look: Settings → Privacy, then the *Privacy Settings* link, and under Preferences the row [Help improve our AI models](#) — "Allow the use of your chats and coding sessions to train and improve Anthropic AI models." Check it on every account your staff use before anyone types anything about students, even de-identified. Hold it against your school's AI policy, and turn it off if you are unsure.

Getting Started

If you have never opened Claude before, start here. By the end of this part you will have an account, you will know how to write a prompt that does not waste your time, and you will have five concrete things you can use with your classes this week.



Creating your account

Go to claude.ai and sign up. You can use a Google or Apple sign-in, or register with any email address. To find out if Claude is a useful tool for you or not, you can try a free personal account to start with — just don't upload any sensitive data. If you feel that your school should have Claude accounts for you, there are several steps that need to be addressed and resolved before you are up and running.

The free tier is genuinely useful. You get Claude Sonnet 5.5, memory across conversations, web search, file uploads and file creation, and the mobile apps. Most of this guide works on the free

tier. Start there. Upgrade when you find yourself running out of usage in the middle of a productive session — not before.

Web (claude.ai)

Fastest start. No install, no permissions, no IT ticket. Open the browser, sign in, start typing. If you only want to try Claude before committing to anything, this is where to begin.

Desktop app (macOS and Windows)

Recommended for daily use. The desktop app runs outside your browser, which means you are not fighting thirty open tabs when you want to think. It is also the route to anything on your own machine: when a task needs a local file or your browser, Claude reaches it through the desktop app.

Mobile (iOS and Android)

Install both. Voice input is the hidden productivity feature. A ten-minute walk between classrooms is long enough to dictate a draft parent email, a feedback summary, or a rough lesson outline. You edit the text later, on a proper keyboard. What gets written on the walk would otherwise never get written.

Your first prompt — the RTF anatomy

Most prompts fail not because the model is bad, but because the prompt is too vague. A useful prompt has three parts: Role, Task, Format. Three letters: R, T, F. Get into the habit and the quality of what Claude gives you goes up immediately.

R — Role

Tell Claude who to be. You already do this with colleagues and student teachers: "Imagine you're a Year 8 English teacher in a mixed-ability classroom." The more specific the role, the more grounded the output. "A primary teacher" is weaker than "an experienced Year 4 literacy teacher in a state school with a wide range of reading ages".

T — Task

State exactly what you want done. Not "help me with a quiz" — that leaves too much to guess. Instead: "Create a ten-minute retrieval practice quiz on persuasive techniques covered in the past three lessons." Precision about the task is precision about the output.

F — Format

Specify the shape of the answer. Number of questions, mix of question types, word count, heading structure, whether you want an answer key, whether it should be suitable for a display

slide or a paper handout. Format is where most first drafts go wrong and most fixes get made — so say it up front.

Put the three together and you have a prompt that works on the first try and gets better on the second. Iteration — going back and refining the draft through repeated passes — is part of the skill: Claude's first output is a draft, not a deliverable. Read it, tell Claude what to change, and run again. The second draft is always better than the first, and the third is usually classroom-ready.

TRY THIS WEEK

Open Claude. Write one prompt using the RTF anatomy — Role, Task, Format — for a real task on your desk this week. When the first draft arrives, ask for two changes and run it again. Then ask for one more. Notice what changes between draft one and draft three. That is your skill curve in action.

Bad → Better → Best

Same topic, three drafts of the same prompt. Each draft gets more precise about what Claude needs to know. The output quality climbs with the specificity of the prompt — not with the length of it.

● Bad

Explain the water cycle.

● Better

Explain the water cycle for Year 6 students. Make it easy to understand.

● Best

Act as an experienced Year 6 Science teacher.

Task: Write a one-page explanation of the water cycle suitable for a mixed-ability Year 6 class. Include the four core stages and one real-world example for each.

Format:

- 250-300 words total
- Plain language, short sentences (≤ 15 words where possible)
- One vocabulary box with five key terms and child-friendly definitions
- End with three retrieval questions (two recall, one application)

Pitch: students reading at Year 5 to Year 7 level.

The Best prompt is not longer for its own sake. Every word earns a place by reducing what Claude has to guess.

Five quick wins for this week

Don't try to use Claude for everything at once. Get good at one task, get it into your routine, then add the next. These five are high-value, low-risk starting points. Each one saves at least half an hour of work the first time you do it, and the savings compound as you get faster.

1 · Differentiate a reading passage at three levels

Paste a passage you are planning to use. Ask Claude to produce three versions of it at reading ages two years below, at-level, and two years above, preserving the core ideas and keeping the shared vocabulary intact. The whole job takes five minutes instead of forty, and every student in your room reads about the same subject on the same day.

Try: "Act as a Year 7 English teacher. Below is a reading passage on the Industrial Revolution. Produce three versions at reading ages 10, 12, and 14. Keep the six bolded key terms identical in all three."

2 · Build a retrieval practice quiz

Retrieval practice works. What stops most teachers from running it every lesson is the time cost of generating fresh questions. Claude removes that cost. Give it the topic, the year level, the mix of question types, and the number of questions. Ask for an answer key at the end. You will have a usable draft inside two minutes.

Try: "Act as a Year 10 Science teacher. Create a ten-minute retrieval practice quiz on cellular respiration. Five multiple-choice, five short answer, mixed difficulty. Include an answer key."

3 · Draft a parent communication

You know what you want to say. Writing it well, professionally, and without falling into the six awkward sentences you have used before is what takes time. Give Claude the context — what happened, what you want the parent to know, what tone you want to strike — and let it produce a first draft. Edit. Send. You will never start from a blank page again.

Try: "Draft a short email to parents of Year 8 students about the upcoming assessment week. Professional, warm, clear. Two paragraphs. Include a line reassuring parents of extra-time adjustments for students with learning support plans."

4 · Summarise a long policy document

Teachers are drowning in policy documents they do not have time to read properly. Upload the PDF and ask Claude for the three things you actually need to know, the parts that affect you directly, and any deadlines buried in the document. Read those. Skim the rest. You are now better briefed than the colleague who tried to read it cover to cover at midnight. Make sure you have permission to upload the document to Claude before you do.

Try: "Here is my school district's updated assessment policy. Summarise in three sections: (1) what has changed from last year, (2) what I need to do differently as a classroom teacher, (3) any deadlines in the document."

5 · Create a lesson starter

The first five minutes of a lesson matter more than most of the next fifty. A good starter activates prior knowledge, introduces the day's key vocabulary, or generates a question the lesson will answer. Ask Claude for three options in different formats — a vocabulary warm-up, a sentence-completion task, and a think-pair-share prompt — and pick whichever fits your class.

Try: "Act as a Year 9 History teacher. Today's lesson is on the causes of the First World War. Give me three five-minute starter options: a vocabulary warm-up, a fill-in-the-blanks task, and a think-pair-share question. All pitched at mixed ability."

TRY THIS WEEK

Pick one of the five. Do it for a real lesson this week. The other four will still be there next week. Mastery happens through repetition on one task, not scatter across all five at once.

Part 1 — Before you move on

If you can answer yes to each of these, you are ready for Part 2.

- ☐ I have created a Claude account and signed in at claude.ai

- ☐ I know the difference between asking Claude a question and handing over a whole task — and which of the two my plan gives me today

- ☐ I have written at least three prompts using the RTF anatomy — Role, Task, Format

- ☐ I have iterated on at least one prompt — improving it through two rounds of feedback — for a real task

- ☐ I have completed at least one of the five quick wins for a lesson or task this week

- ☐ I have decided which categories of data are acceptable to share with Claude, and which are not

If any of these is a no, stay here another week. Part 2 assumes the ground in Part 1 is solid.

Working Smarter

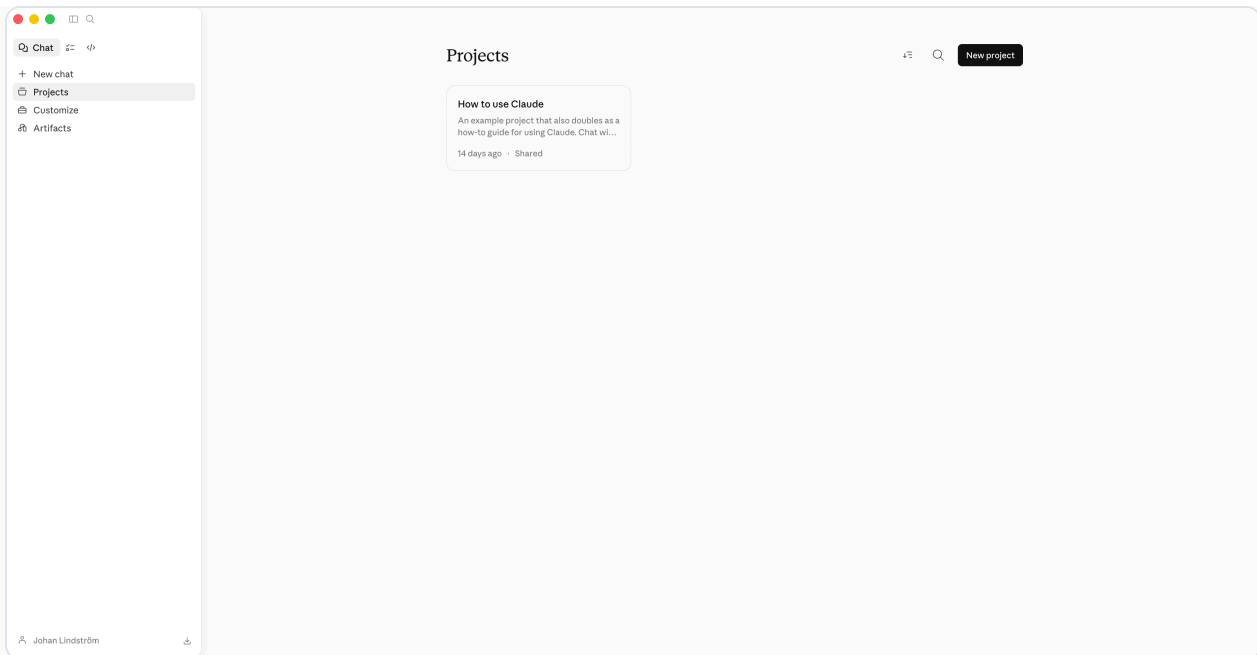
Once you find yourself returning to Claude for the same kind of task week after week, it is time to stop starting from scratch. This part shows you how to make Claude a persistent assistant — one that already knows your subject, your school, and how you like to write.



Projects — your persistent teaching assistant

A Project is a workspace inside Claude. You create one, give it a name, upload reference files, and write a set of custom instructions. Every conversation you start inside that Project draws on those files and follows those instructions — without you having to paste them in again.

This is where Claude stops being generically helpful and starts being genuinely yours. The same prompt that produced a competent-but-bland worksheet outside a Project produces a worksheet that fits your students when it is run inside one. The difference is not about Claude working harder; it is about Claude working with more context.



What to upload to your first Project

Pick your main teaching area — the subject or year level you spend most of your time on. Create a Project for it. Upload five things that together describe your working context:

- **Your curriculum or syllabus** for that subject and year
- **Your scope and sequence** or term planner, if you have one
- **Your school's style guide** or communications guide, if one exists
- **An assessment rubric** you commonly use
- **Three de-identified student work samples** at different performance levels, so Claude has a calibrated sense of what strong, middling, and weak work looks like in your classroom

WATCH OUT · THINK BEFORE YOU SHARE

Before uploading anything to Claude, decide which categories of data are acceptable to share — and which are not.

The instructions that make the difference

Under the Project's settings, add a custom instruction that describes who Claude is for you. Something like:

"You are an experienced Year 8 English teacher in a mixed-ability state school in England. Outputs should be classroom-ready, follow the uploaded style guide, and never produce more than I asked for. If a task involves student data, ask me to confirm the data has been de-identified before proceeding. Use British English spelling."

That paragraph is the difference between spending two minutes explaining your context every conversation and never explaining it again.

TRY THIS WEEK

Spend twenty minutes setting up your first Project. Upload three documents. Write the instructions. Then run yesterday's worst prompt inside the Project and notice the difference. That twenty minutes is the highest-leverage time you will spend on AI all year.

Artifacts — turn chats into downloadable documents

When you ask Claude to create something — a worksheet, a rubric, a quiz, a letter home, a vocabulary handout — it can produce a downloadable file directly in the conversation. These appear beside the chat as artifacts. You download them, edit them, and iterate without ever leaving the browser.

Common output formats: Word documents, PDFs, PowerPoint decks, Excel spreadsheets with formulas, plain text, HTML, Markdown. For most classroom materials, Word or PDF is what you want.

Three newer artifact types sit alongside those formats. **Claude Docs** produces documents, **Claude Slides** produces slide decks, and **Claude Design** brings visual design work into the conversation. Unlike the formats above, none of the three is available on Free: they belong to the paid plans, so check what the room is signed in with before you plan a session around them.

A workflow that compounds

Ask for the resource. Review the artifact Claude produces. Ask for two specific changes ("Make the font larger; replace the third example with one about primary sources"). Run it again. Download the final version. Total time from "I need a rubric" to "rubric is on my desk": four minutes on the first go, two on the tenth.

Files — let Claude read your curriculum

Claude handles long documents exceptionally well. You can upload PDFs, Word documents, spreadsheets, images, and slides. File uploads are where Claude earns its most underrated keep: reading the documents you never have time to read yourself.

Three high-value uses for teachers and school leaders:

- **Summarise a long policy document.** Upload it, ask for the three things that actually affect you, any deadlines buried in the text, and any changes from a previous version you also upload.
- **Map an existing unit against a curriculum document.** Upload your unit plan and the curriculum standards and ask Claude to identify gaps, overlaps, and opportunities.

- **Analyse de-identified student work for feedback patterns.** Upload eight to ten anonymised responses and ask Claude to identify recurring strengths and recurring misconceptions, then suggest the three highest-leverage teaching moves for the next lesson.

WATCH OUT · THINK BEFORE YOU SHARE

Before uploading anything to Claude, decide which categories of data are acceptable to share — and which are not. Public curriculum documents, policy PDFs, your own lesson notes and slides are usually fine. Student names, grades, behavioural records, health information, parent contact details, anything that identifies a young person — never. De-identify everything. Replace names with roles ("Student A", "Student B"). Generalise dates and locations. If you are unsure whether a document is safe to upload, treat it as if it is not, and ask your school's data protection officer before you proceed.

Styles & Memory — make Claude sound like you

Two small features that dramatically reduce repetition.

Styles

Styles are voice presets. You save one called "Parent communication — warm, clear, professional, no jargon" and another called "Staff meeting brief — concise, action-oriented, bullet-led". When you start a relevant task, you pick the Style from a drop-down, and the output arrives already in the voice you want.

Most teachers end up with three or four Styles. That is usually enough to cover eighty per cent of their writing tasks.

Memory

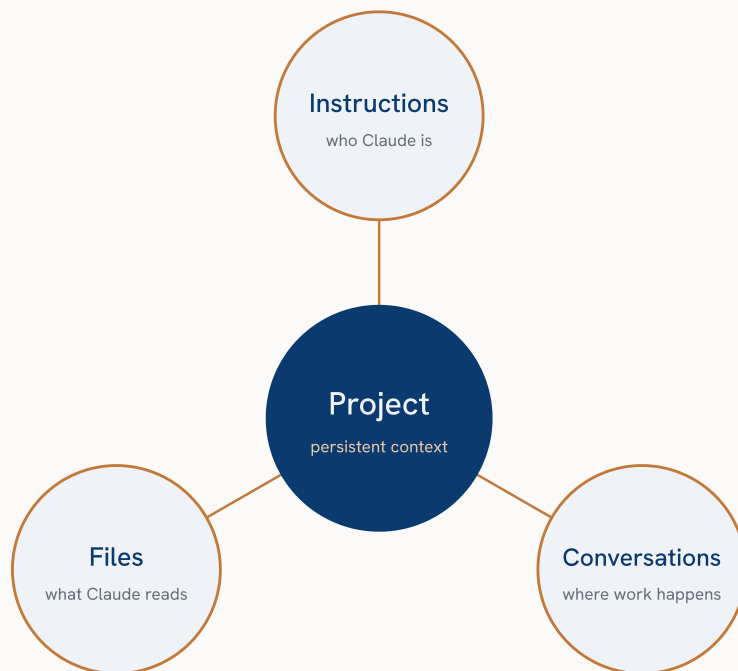
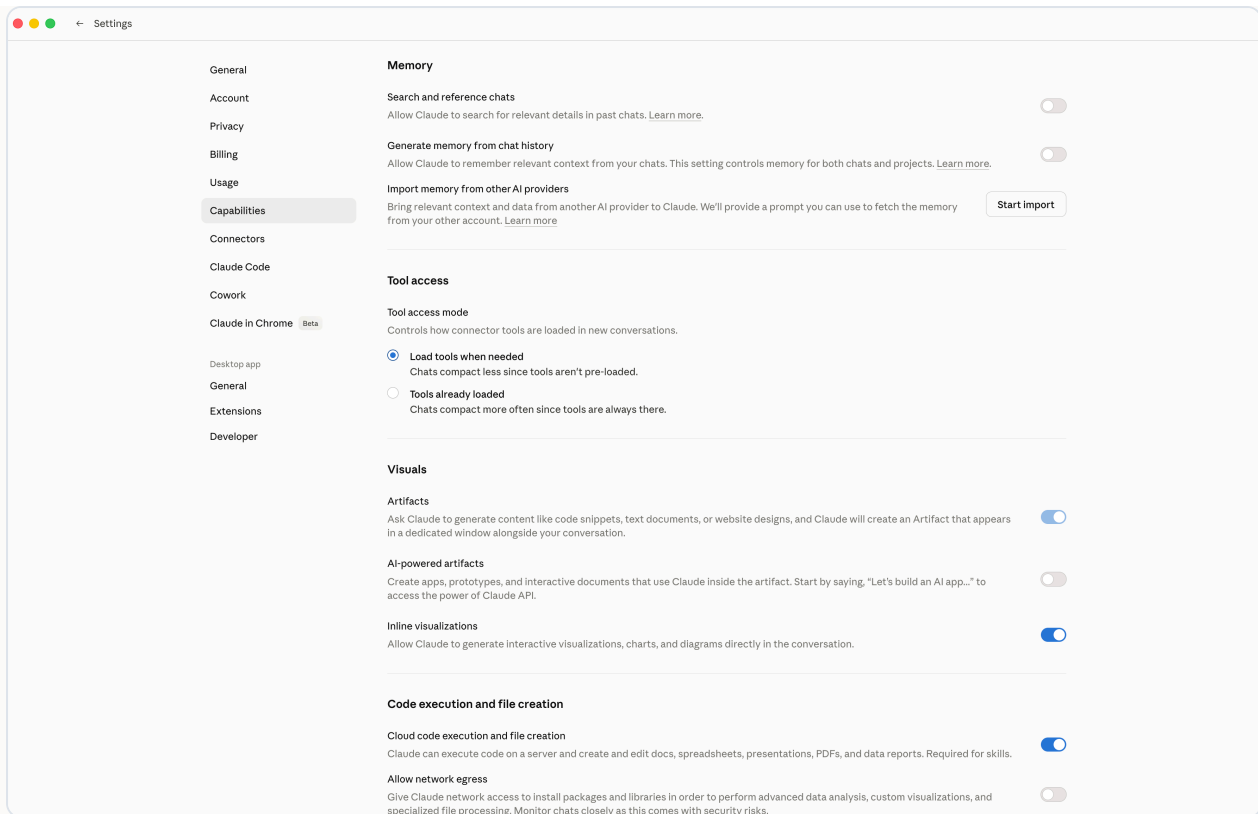
Claude can remember things about you across conversations — your role, the year you teach, your school context, the way you like outputs formatted. It is not one switch you flick on: the Memory section in Settings holds three separate controls, and they do not all start in the same position.

Setting Memory up

Open Settings and go to the Memory section. Read all three controls before you decide anything. **Search and reference chats** lets Claude look back through earlier conversations. **Generate memory from chats** lets it build memory out of what you write. **Include sensitive topics in memory** governs whether details such as health conditions or religious beliefs are saved at all — in a school, that is the one to read hardest. Then, in your first few conversations, tell Claude about yourself in plain sentences:

"I am a Year 8 English teacher at a mixed-ability state school in Manchester. I teach four classes of around twenty-five students. I value evidence-based practice, I like outputs that are clean and classroom-ready, and I prefer British English spelling."

Claude will remember this across conversations. The same Memory section lists what it has stored, so it is also where you go to see what Claude thinks it knows about you.



A Project is the smallest unit of compounding value in Claude. Set it up once; benefit from it every conversation.

Five classroom workflows that compound

Single prompts produce single outputs. The real leverage is in workflows — prompt patterns you reuse week after week, embedded inside a Project, where the files and instructions do half the work for you. Here are five that pay back quickly.

1 · Weekly lesson planning from learning objectives

Start from your weekly objective, your year level, and the time you have. Ask Claude for a lesson skeleton: a five-minute starter, a main task with differentiation at three levels, an exit ticket. Five minutes of work replaces what was previously a forty-minute planning block. You keep the pedagogical decisions; Claude handles the drafting.

2 · Marking feedback patterns from de-identified work

Upload eight to ten de-identified responses to the same task. Ask Claude to identify the three recurring strengths, the three recurring misconceptions, and the single highest-leverage thing to teach next. What comes back is usually what you would have concluded yourself, but faster and with the comfort of having had a second set of eyes on the same pile. Use it as a prompt for your own judgment, not a replacement for it.

3 · Differentiated instruction generator

Any teaching resource — a reading passage, a worksheet, a set of instructions — can be differentiated in three directions: simplified, extended, and EAL vocabulary scaffold. Set this up once inside your Project and the prompt becomes a standing pattern: "Produce the three versions for the attached resource, following the scaffolding I described in my Project instructions."

4 · For school leaders — staff meeting preparation

Upload the agenda, any pre-reads, and recent meeting minutes. Ask Claude to produce a one-page meeting brief with the decisions to be made, time allocations per item, questions to anticipate from staff, and suggested follow-up actions if each decision goes one way or the other. You walk into the meeting better prepared than the last three times you led one.

5 · For school leaders — policy drafting

Claude produces a first draft of a policy from a brief. You provide the context — the problem, the constraints, the stakeholders, the legal framework — and ask for a draft. Edit, iterate, circulate. A first draft is always a starting point for human judgment; it is never the final. But a good first draft gets a policy moving weeks earlier than it otherwise would.

JOHAN'S NOTE

The teachers I work with who get the most out of Claude are not the ones who use it most often. They are the ones who built three or four workflows into their weekly routine and then stopped adding new ones. Depth beats breadth every time. Pick two of the five above, run them for half a term, and only then add a third.

—JL

Scale & Lead

Part 3 is for educators who want to do more than save personal time. It is for those building a system — for their classroom, their team, their school. The tools and patterns here change what a single educator can take on.



Handing Claude a whole task

Parts 1 and 2 were about asking better questions. This part begins with the opposite move: not asking a question at all, but describing a job and letting Claude carry it out. Several steps, several outputs, one finished result. Claude plans the work, does it, and uses tools along the way until it is done — the same agentic machinery that drives Claude Code, without a terminal anywhere in sight.

You remain in the loop while it works. You can watch each step, interrupt, and point it somewhere else. What you have stopped doing is the orchestration: the chaining of one prompt into the next, which is the part that used to eat the morning.

Anthropic used to sell this as a separate mode called Cowork, and is merging it into Claude itself — the Pro and Max plans first, with Team and Free to follow. If your account still shows Cowork as its own choice, this chapter is what sits behind it. If it does not, and your plan includes it, you describe the job in the ordinary way and Claude takes it from there. The work, and your responsibility for the result, are identical either way.

Where the work actually runs

This is worth a paragraph of its own, because it decides what a school may legitimately use this for. The work does not happen on your laptop. Claude's work runs in an isolated environment on Anthropic's servers, separate from your computer and your network; on Team and Enterprise plans that cloud execution is still in beta. Local files are not out of reach — when a task needs a file on your machine, or your browser, Claude reaches it through the Claude Desktop app — but the processing itself happens on Anthropic's side. The data discipline section later in this part, and the bonus chapter for EU readers, both turn on that fact.

When to hand over instead of ask

Handing over earns its keep on tasks that would otherwise require you to write three, five, or ten chained prompts yourself. For example:

- "Plan a five-week unit on photosynthesis. Include weekly learning objectives, one lesson outline per week, a formative assessment in week three, a summative project brief for week five, and a single-page parent-facing overview."
- "Draft a parent newsletter for this month. Pull the events from the attached school calendar, add a short note from the head teacher, a celebration of three students' achievements (I will supply the names as placeholders), and a reminder about the upcoming assessment week. Format as one printable A4 page."
- "Produce a consistent set of differentiated resources for the Year 9 Industrial Revolution unit: one simplified reading, one at-level reading, one extension reading, a vocabulary sheet with child-friendly definitions, and a retrieval quiz, for each of the four lesson topics."

Each of these would have been a morning of chained prompts. Handed over whole, each is a single request.

A school leader's example

A principal I worked with recently handed Claude a whole job: the first draft of a staff handbook. She uploaded the school's existing policies, a template from a partner school, and the leadership team's notes from a planning day, and described the job in one go: a unified draft

that preserved the school's voice, a list of every contradiction it found between the existing policies, and a one-page summary of what had changed. Claude took about six minutes. Editing the draft into the final version took her another two hours. The alternative — starting from a blank page — would have taken a weekend.

Note what the six minutes did not do. It did not decide what the school's position should be on anything. It produced a draft that a professional then argued with for two hours, which is exactly the right division of labour.

WATCH OUT · AUTONOMY

A handed-over task is far more autonomous than a conversation. Claude takes several steps in sequence without checking in between every one. That speed is the point — but it also means errors can propagate further before you catch them. Read everything it produces before you send it anywhere or act on it. Treat every finished task like a draft from a junior colleague who works very fast and sometimes gets things confidently wrong.

Skills — your reusable teaching agents

Skills are small, named instructions that Claude loads when it recognises a relevant task. You build one, give it a name, and from then on any conversation where the task fits triggers the Skill automatically. It is a way of teaching Claude the specific patterns you use, so you do not have to explain them every time.

A Skill worth building

Consider a Skill called *differentiate-three-levels*. You write it once. It describes exactly how you want any piece of text rewritten at a simpler reading age, at-level, and an extended version, with shared bolded key vocabulary, a glossary, and no change to the underlying ideas. From then on, every time you paste a text and ask "differentiate this", Claude applies the Skill exactly — no need to re-specify the scaffolding.

Another Skill candidate: *parent-email-template*. Your school's tone, your preferred structure, the standard sign-off, the attachment reminders. Written once, invoked whenever.

When Skills are worth the effort

The rule of three. If you find yourself explaining the same pattern to Claude more than three times, it is time to make it a Skill. Below that threshold, keep prompting and iterating. Above it, invest the fifteen minutes to codify the pattern.

A growing library of education Skills has been published openly — Gareth Manning's *education-agent-skills* repository on GitHub is one starting point and is credited in the references page. You do not need to start from a blank page; adapt what others have built.

Claude Code — a glimpse

For most teachers, Claude Code is not a daily tool. But it is worth knowing it exists, because it is where Claude becomes most powerful, and where your school's IT staff or curriculum lead may want to spend time.

Claude Code is a command-line tool that runs on macOS, Windows, and Linux. Claude can read and write files on your computer, run programs, and execute multi-step plans across your filesystem. Three examples of what it unlocks:

- Bulk-renaming and reorganising a folder of hundreds of classroom resources to match a new naming convention, in minutes rather than an afternoon
- Building a small website for a class project, using only plain-language descriptions of what the site should do
- Automating the production of a year's worth of differentiated worksheets from a curriculum document and a rubric

If your school has a tech-curious teacher, a curriculum administrator with a technical streak, or an IT lead, point them at Claude Code. It is where their skills compound.

Whole-school rollout — training, policy, governance

For school leaders considering Claude beyond personal use, three things matter more than anything else: how you train, what you codify, and who is accountable. Getting any of them wrong is the difference between AI that raises the floor across a school and AI that creates inconsistency, risk, and resentment.

Training

Most schools default to the one-off workshop: a visiting expert, two hours on a staff day, a slide deck circulated afterwards. Two weeks later, nothing has changed in classrooms. This pattern does not work for AI any better than it works for any other professional learning.

What works is a small working group that meets regularly — once a fortnight for a term is enough — where staff bring real tasks, learn together, and document the patterns that work in the school's specific context. The group is facilitated by a teacher or leader who is one step ahead, not three. Everyone progresses together. The documentation produced by the group becomes the school's own guide, grounded in its own practice.

Policy

Every school using AI needs a written AI policy. Not aspirational, not abstract, but specific enough that a staff member facing a real situation can look up what to do. At minimum, the policy should answer:

- Which categories of data may be shared with Claude, and which may not
- Who to ask when the answer is unclear
- How staff should document AI use in lesson planning, assessment, or communications
- What staff should do when a student is suspected of submitting AI-generated work
- What the school's position is on AI use by students, by year group
- How the school will review and update the policy — and how often

The policy is a living document. Review it every term. Expect the first version to be wrong in at least one place; the point is that it is written, known, and improvable.

Governance

Someone owns AI in the school. It can be a single leader or a small team, but a clear owner is non-negotiable. Without one, responsibility diffuses and decisions drift. The owner's job: stay current with Claude and the regulatory environment, brief the senior leadership team, run the staff working group, escalate issues to the governing body, and keep the policy up to date.

JOHAN'S NOTE

I have consulted with schools across Sweden and the Nordics through the early years of AI adoption. The schools that do it well share one thing in common, and it is not that they bought the fanciest tool. It is that someone in senior leadership made AI part of their job description — explicitly, on paper — and protected time for it. Every school that struggled had AI as "everyone's responsibility", which is to say, no one's.

—JL

Ethics — when NOT to use Claude

Every tool tells you what it is for. Few tell you what it is not for. This section is the latter.

Hallucinations

Claude can produce content that sounds entirely plausible and is factually wrong. It can fabricate sources, misstate facts, and present confident conclusions based on nothing. It is most prone to this on niche, technical, very recent, or numerically precise topics. You know your subject. You know what good looks like. Use that expertise to check everything before it reaches a student.

WATCH OUT

Never hand a student an AI-generated resource you have not read carefully yourself. Fluency makes errors harder to spot, not easier. A confidently-worded factual mistake in a classroom resource undermines the lesson and your credibility at the same time.

Data discipline

The rule from Part 2 repeats here, at the school level: decide in advance which categories of data are acceptable to share with Claude and which are not. Public curriculum documents and your own lesson notes are usually fine. Student names, grades, health information, behavioural records, parent contact details, anything that identifies a young person — never.

Apply the same discipline to **giving Claude access to folders and connected services**. Handed-over tasks, Claude Code, and Connectors (the feature that plugs Claude into your other tools and data sources; MCP is the protocol underneath) can reach into your filesystem, your email, your cloud storage. Only grant access to folders and tools that contain data you would be comfortable sharing in a chat. Treat folder access the way you would treat handing someone the key to a filing cabinet: only when necessary, only to the specific drawer that contains what the task requires, and never the whole cabinet by default.

And be clear with yourself about where the work is done, because it is easy to assume wrongly. A task you start in the desktop app does not run in the desktop app. Claude's work runs in an isolated environment on Anthropic's servers, separate from your computer and your network — cloud execution that is still in beta on the Team and Enterprise plans. The desktop app is the route to your local files, not the place the work happens: it is how Claude reaches a file on your

machine, or your browser, while the task itself runs on Anthropic's side. For a school in the EU this is the difference between local processing on a teacher's laptop and processing by a provider outside your own infrastructure — and only the second of those is actually true. Grant folder access on that understanding, and take the question to the bonus chapter, where the GDPR consequences are set out.

Automating the wrong things

The worst use of AI in education is not cheating. It is teachers using AI to produce work that should not exist, for students who use AI to complete it, for teachers who use AI to mark it. A feedback loop of automation on both sides of a task that has lost its purpose.

Before you ask Claude to help with a task, ask two prior questions. Is this task genuinely worth doing? And: is it the kind of work I should be doing myself, for my own development as a professional? If the honest answers are no and yes, Claude is the wrong tool. The task is the problem, not the speed at which it is completed.

The formation question

Not every task should be outsourced — even when it could be. Writing, thinking, planning, reflecting are not only tasks. They are how teachers grow as professionals. If AI does all your thinking, you stop developing. The same is true for your students. Use AI for the mechanical. Keep the meaningful.

The long-term measure of whether AI is helping your school is not how many hours it saves. It is whether the teachers using it are becoming more skilled at teaching — or less. Hold that measure up every term. Act on what it tells you.

For EU readers

If you teach or lead a school in an EU member state, two regulations shape how you use Claude: the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the EU AI Act. This chapter is a practical primer — not legal advice.

GDPR fundamentals for schools

The GDPR has been in force since 2018. Most teachers and school leaders have attended at least one training on it. What often gets lost is how the principles apply specifically to a tool like Claude — a general-purpose AI service hosted outside the school's own systems. Four points matter most in day-to-day use.

Lawful basis

Schools usually rely on public task or legitimate interests as the lawful basis for processing student data. Do not assume you have student or parent consent unless you actively sought it for a specific, clearly-described purpose. "We use AI in the school" is not consent. "We use Claude to generate feedback on your child's work, here is how the data is handled" is.

Data minimisation

Share only what you need to share. If you are asking Claude to analyse a paragraph of a student's writing, paste that paragraph — not the full essay, and definitely not the essay with the student's name attached. If you are summarising a policy, extract the relevant pages rather than uploading the whole document. The question is always: what is the least amount of data that still lets Claude do the task well?

Student data is personal data

Yes, even when you think it has been anonymised. True anonymisation — the kind where the data could never be re-identified — is harder than it looks. Pseudonymisation (replacing names

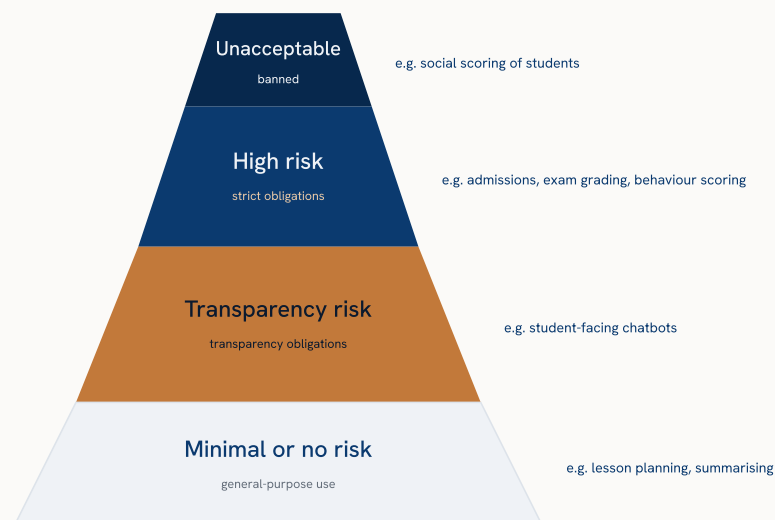
with codes like "Student A") is more realistic and is the safer default for classroom use. Treat pseudonymised data as personal data still, because it is.

Records of processing (Article 30)

If your school uses Claude routinely — for lesson planning, communications, analysis of student work — your school's records of processing should reflect that. The school's Data Protection Officer will have these records. When you adopt any new routine use of Claude, tell the DPO. Keep the records current.

The EU AI Act — what it means for schools

The EU AI Act entered into force on 1 August 2024 and became applicable on 2 August 2026. It classifies AI use by risk level and attaches obligations to each level. Education is explicitly in scope, and the uses that decide a student's access to education — admissions, the scoring of exams — sit in the high-risk tier. The deadline for those obligations has moved: through the AI Omnibus, the Annex III uses that cover education apply from 2 December 2027, and high-risk systems built into products from 2 August 2028. Read that as runway, not as exemption. One duty is already in force, and has been since 2 February 2025: AI literacy — the people in your organisation who use these systems must be competent to do so.



Risk classification dictates obligations. Most teachers' day-to-day Claude use sits in the bottom two tiers; school leaders deploying AI for admissions, grading, or behaviour scoring must engage with high-risk obligations.

Where school use typically sits

Minimal or no risk: lesson planning, drafting communications, summarising your own notes, differentiating texts, producing rubrics. This is where most classroom use sits. Standard data-protection discipline applies; specific AI Act obligations are light.

Transparency risk: student-facing chatbots or Claude-powered tools that interact with students directly. Transparency obligations apply: students must be told they are interacting with an AI, not a human.

High risk: AI used to evaluate students in ways that determine access to education — admissions decisions, exam grading, assessment of behaviour that affects placement. Strict obligations apply: risk-management systems, documentation, human oversight, logging, accuracy requirements. Engage your Data Protection Officer and legal counsel before deploying anything in this category.

Unacceptable risk: banned outright. Social scoring of students, emotion-recognition systems in schools used to infer student mental states for assessment, any system exploiting vulnerabilities of a specific group of children. Do not deploy these regardless of what a vendor tells you.

A practical compliance checklist

If you can answer yes to each of these, you have a defensible starting point — not a finished compliance position.

- 1 We have a written AI policy that staff have read and acknowledged
- 2 The policy names a single owner accountable for AI use at our school
- 3 We have decided which categories of data are acceptable to share with Claude — and which are not
- 4 Staff know how to de-identify student data before any upload
- 5 We have reviewed Claude's privacy settings and checked, on each account we use, how the setting *Help improve our AI models* stands
- 6 Our records of processing (Article 30) reflect any routine use of Claude
- 7 We have classified our intended uses of Claude against the EU AI Act risk tiers
- 8 We have engaged our DPO on any high-risk uses (admissions, grading, behaviour scoring)
- 9 We have a process for staff to raise concerns about AI use without consequence
- 10 We review the policy at least once per term, and after any significant regulatory change

WATCH OUT · A NOTE FROM JOHAN

I am not a lawyer. This guide gives you a starting point, not legal advice. Make sure the checklist harmonises with your own organisation's interpretation of the GDPR and the EU AI Act, and consult your Data Protection Officer or legal counsel for binding decisions.

Appendix — Prompt library

Fifteen prompts you can copy, paste, and adapt. Each uses the RTF anatomy — Role, Task, Format. Parts in [square brackets] are the places where you customise for your context. The online version of this guide carries ten more prompts and keeps the library current.

For teachers

1 · Differentiate a reading passage at three levels

Act as an experienced [year level] [subject] teacher in a mixed-ability classroom.

Task: Below this prompt is a reading passage. Produce three versions of it — at reading ages [age - 2], [at-level age], and [age + 2] — preserving the core ideas and keeping the six bolded key terms identical across all three versions.

Format: Label each version clearly. 150–250 words per version. Plain language in the simplified version; extended vocabulary in the advanced version.

[paste reading passage here]

2 · Retrieval practice quiz generator

Act as an experienced [year level] [subject] teacher.

Task: Create a [10]-minute retrieval practice quiz on [topic], covering material from the past [three] lessons.

Format:

- [5] multiple-choice questions (four options each)
- [5] short-answer questions
- Mixed difficulty
- Answer key at the end with brief explanations for each answer

3 · Marking feedback patterns from de-identified work

Act as an experienced [year level] [subject] teacher.

Task: Below are [8] de-identified student responses to the same task. Identify (1) the three recurring strengths, (2) the three recurring misconceptions, and (3) the single highest-leverage thing I should teach next. Do not comment on any individual student – aggregate only.

Format: Three numbered sections, bullet points under each.

[paste de-identified responses]

4 · Rubric builder

Act as an experienced [subject] teacher.

Task: Produce a four-level rubric for a [year level] [assessment type, e.g. persuasive essay]. The rubric should assess [criterion 1], [criterion 2], [criterion 3], and [criterion 4].

Format:

- Single-page table
- Four achievement levels: Emerging, Developing, Secure, Extending
- One descriptor per criterion per level, in student-facing language
- Include one example of what "Secure" work looks like at the end

5 · Parent communication template

Draft a short email to parents of [year level] students about [topic].

Tone: professional, warm, clear – no jargon. Assume parents are busy.

Format: two short paragraphs plus a closing sentence. Include a line reassuring parents of any support available to students who need it. Sign off: "Kind regards, [my name]".

Context:

[1–3 sentences about what happened or what parents need to know]

6 · Reading passage rewriter

Rewrite the reading passage below for students with a reading age of [age]. Preserve every factual claim. Shorten sentences (≤ 15 words where possible). Replace low-frequency vocabulary with more accessible alternatives except for the bolded key terms, which must remain.

[paste original passage]

7 · Vocabulary list with child-friendly definitions

Produce a vocabulary list for [topic] for [year level] students. Include [10] key terms. For each term provide: a child-friendly definition, a sentence showing the term used in context, and one question that checks understanding.

Format: table with four columns – Term · Definition · Example · Check question.

8 · Exit ticket generator

Act as an experienced [subject] teacher.

Task: Produce three exit-ticket options for today's lesson on [topic]. Each option should take no more than 3 minutes to complete.

Format: (1) a two-question recall check, (2) a one-sentence explanation prompt, (3) a single "what's one thing you're still unsure about?" reflection prompt. Label each clearly.

For school leaders

9 · Staff meeting brief from agenda

Below are the agenda and any pre-reads for tomorrow's staff meeting. Produce a one-page brief for me (the chair) covering:

1. The key decisions to be made, in order of importance
2. Time allocations I should target for each item
3. Two or three questions I should anticipate from staff per item, and a short response for each
4. Suggested follow-up actions depending on how each decision lands

[paste agenda and pre-reads]

10 · First-draft policy from brief

Produce a first draft of a school policy on [topic].

Context: [2–3 sentences on the problem the policy addresses, the stakeholders involved, and any legal or regulatory framework]

Format:

- Purpose (one paragraph)
- Scope (who and what the policy applies to)
- Key principles (3–5 bullet points)
- Specific procedures (numbered steps)
- Review cycle (how often, by whom)
- No more than two A4 pages

Voice: clear, accessible to non-specialists, avoids jargon.

11 · Parent newsletter from sources

Draft this month's parent newsletter for [school name]. Use the attached calendar, head teacher's message draft, and list of student achievements.

Format:

- Single printable A4 page
- Warm, not corporate, tone
- Sections: Head teacher's message, This month's highlights, Important dates, Celebrations (student achievements)
- Keep the calendar events factual; weave the head teacher's message into the Highlights section

[attach sources]

12 · Observation feedback synthesis

Below are my lesson observation notes from [n] observations this term. Identify the three recurring areas of strength across the department and the three recurring areas for development. For each development area, suggest one concrete coaching conversation a team leader could open with.

Format: two numbered sections. Aggregate only – do not reference any individual teacher.

[paste observation notes]

13 · The first-meeting Claude setup prompt

I'd like you to remember some things about me:

I am a [role, e.g. Year 8 English teacher] at a [type of school] in [country]. I teach [n] classes of around [n] students in a [mixed-ability / selective] setting. I value [evidence-based practice / creativity / specific pedagogy].

My preferences for outputs:

- Concise unless I ask for depth
- [British / American] English spelling
- Classroom-ready – minimal editing required
- Ask me to confirm de-identification before any task involving student data

Please confirm you've saved this.

14 · Analyse this document

I'm uploading a [document type]. Give me:

1. A one-paragraph summary
2. The three things that affect me directly as a [role]
3. Any deadlines in the document
4. Any contradictions with [another source / my practice] to flag
5. Questions I should ask before acting on this

Format: numbered sections, bullet points where useful.

15 · Explain it to me as if I'm new

I've just been given responsibility for [task, role, or area]. Explain what I need to understand, in plain language, assuming no prior expertise.

Format:

- The three things I must understand before I do anything
- The two most common mistakes new people in this role make
- One concrete action I should take in my first week
- One concrete action I should take in my first month
- What "good" looks like after six months

Avoid jargon. If a term is unavoidable, define it in a sentence.

Choose WISE

This guide is a starting point, not a destination. You now know where Claude sits in the education landscape, how to write prompts that do not waste your time, and how to use Claude as a persistent companion rather than a one-off novelty. You know what to watch out for. You have five tasks you can try this week, fifteen prompts you can copy into any chat, and — if you teach in the EU — a compliance checklist that is more specific than most guidance you have seen.

AI is moving fast. The fundamentals of good teaching are not. Know your students. Plan with purpose. Use evidence. Be present. Claude can help you do some of that better than you could before. It cannot replace any of it.

The most useful thing I have learned across twenty-eight years in education is this: the tools that last are the ones that let teachers do more of what they already knew worked, with less of the drag. Claude, used well, sits in that category. Used badly, it ends up in the pile of things schools bought and never used. The difference is almost entirely in the hands of the people using it.

Choose WISE.

For updates, an expanded online version of this guide, more prompts and other AI-news and resources, visit my website: choosewise.education

About the author

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Johan has spent twenty-eight years in the Swedish education sector: ten years as a classroom teacher, seven as a school leader, and eleven years in EdTech at Advania Skolpartner, which he has since left to work for himself as an independent consultant. He is a recognised authority on AI and digitalisation in Swedish schools, and works primarily with school administrators, principals, and teachers to translate fast-moving technology into practical classroom and leadership practice.

He is the founder of JL Skolutveckling AB, through which he writes, speaks, and consults on AI in education, source criticism, the EU AI Act, and what makes whole-school AI adoption actually work. His writing challenges mainstream narratives and favours evidence-based practice over novelty. Johan writes and speaks in Swedish and English, and splits his time between school visits, leadership coaching, and the long-form work that becomes guides like this one.

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— *Johan Lindström*

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